

can get online. With the ample supply of one-time-use samples I've received, I have been able to enjoy some of my favorite brands at times when access to them would be scarce. (With each birth of a child, for example, I would pack the samples into my baby bag for my first shower at the hospital. After three or four days of hospital care, having the tiny packets of my favorite body wash in my institutionalized beauty routine seemed like heaven.)

Other fun uses for them? Send them with kids going to summer camp, tuck them into a car kit for unexpected road trips, or add them to that "hotel mini" collection mentioned above. (To cut down on waste, I would personally avoid collecting items I would be certain not to use. It is clutter. Let's be responsible here.)

3. Shop till you drop

This tip takes much more work, but can net you some great deals on your top brands. Many seasoned savers have been successful at scouting out retail and drugstore clearance deals in the health and beauty aisles and pairing them with high-value manufacturers' coupons. Many websites track the best deals on items. Just be sure you are buying things you will use, and don't hog items for the thrill

of it. Overconsumption is *not* the goal.

4. Free after rebate

Some folks despise the effort involved with purchasing a product on the premise that it will be free after a mail-in rebate. Several online and retail outlets, however, make this an easy choice for shoppers. Many large chain drugstores feature three to six monthly brand-name items for nothing out of pocket (but tax) after rebate. Rebates are easy to obtain, thanks to their dependable tracking system and online submission forms (which sometimes won't require even the cost of a postage stamp). With unique incentives (like 10% bonuses for rebates that are placed on gift cards, for example), it's possible to buy your favorite items for completely free, including the price you paid in tax. If you are getting items that won't rot in the back of your closet, you can add \$10–20 to your health and beauty budget. With items ranging from hair dye to cold medicine, I have found it to be an excellent deal.

5. Bulk-buy with a buddy

I'm no sucker for those giant bottles of mouthwash packaged together at the warehouse stores. They are